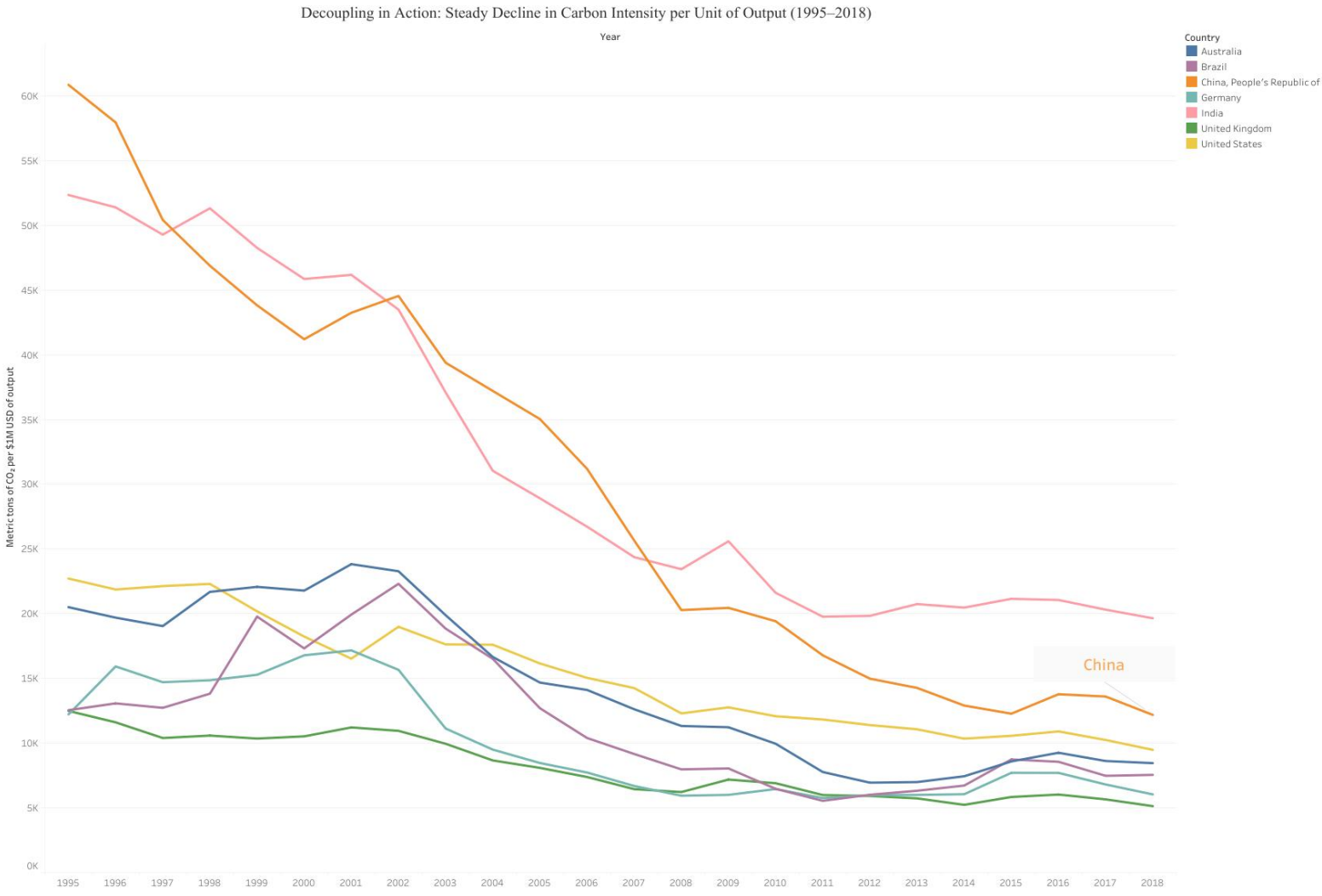
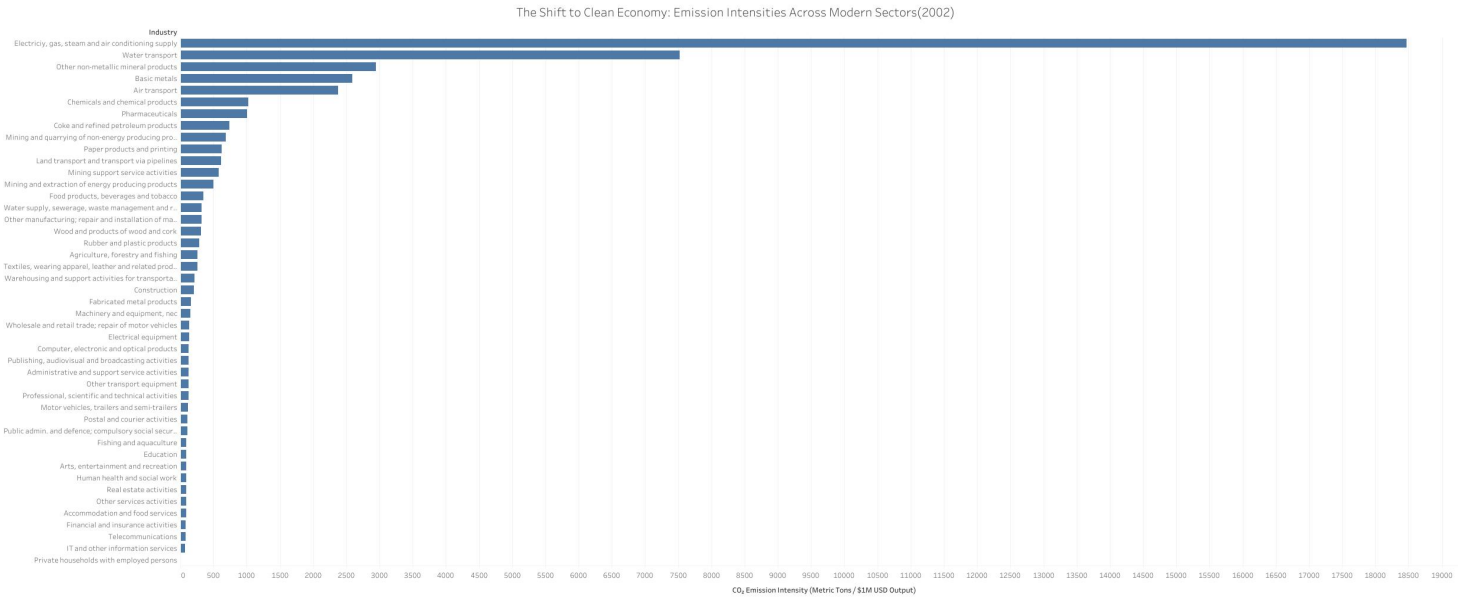
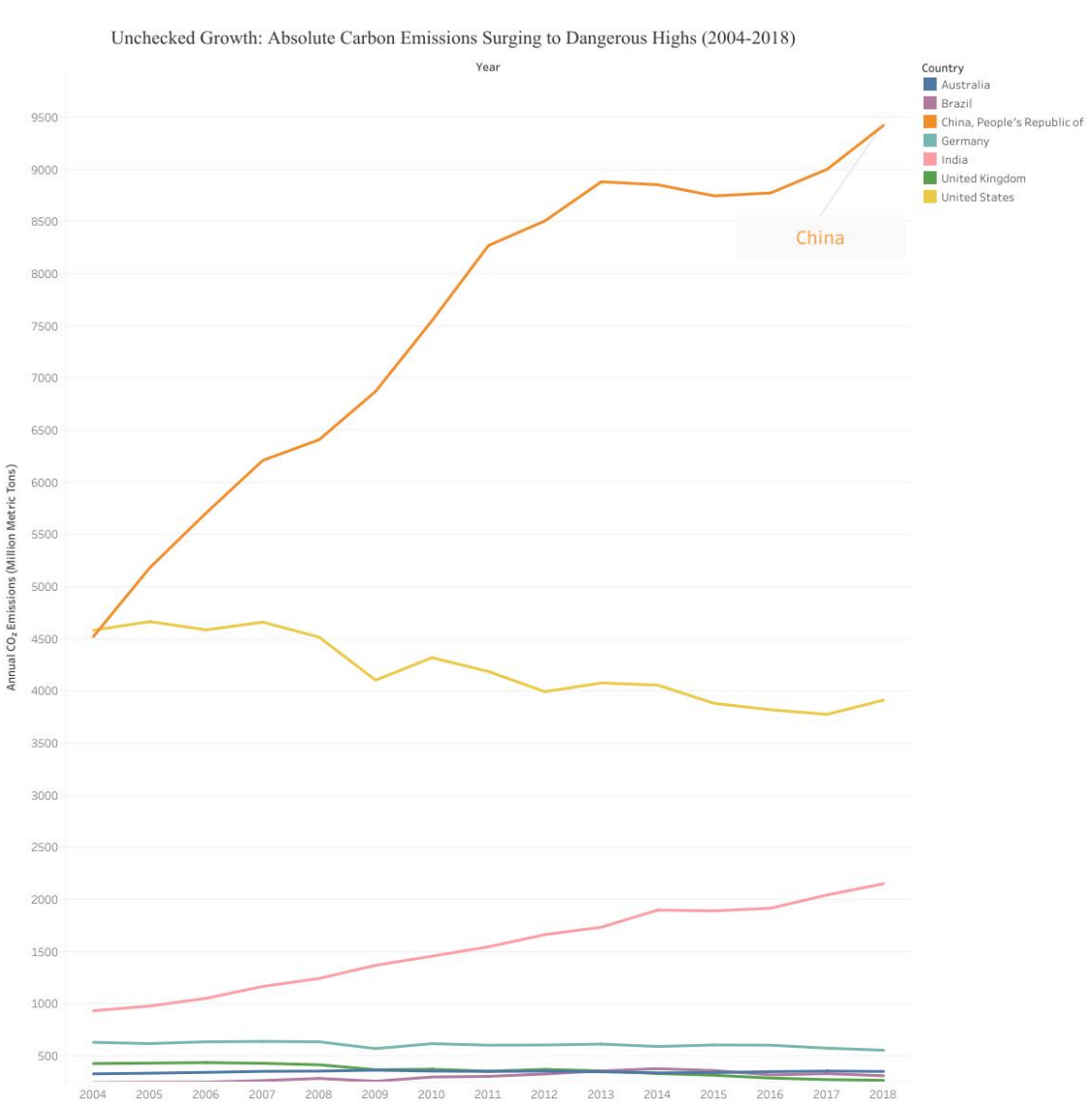


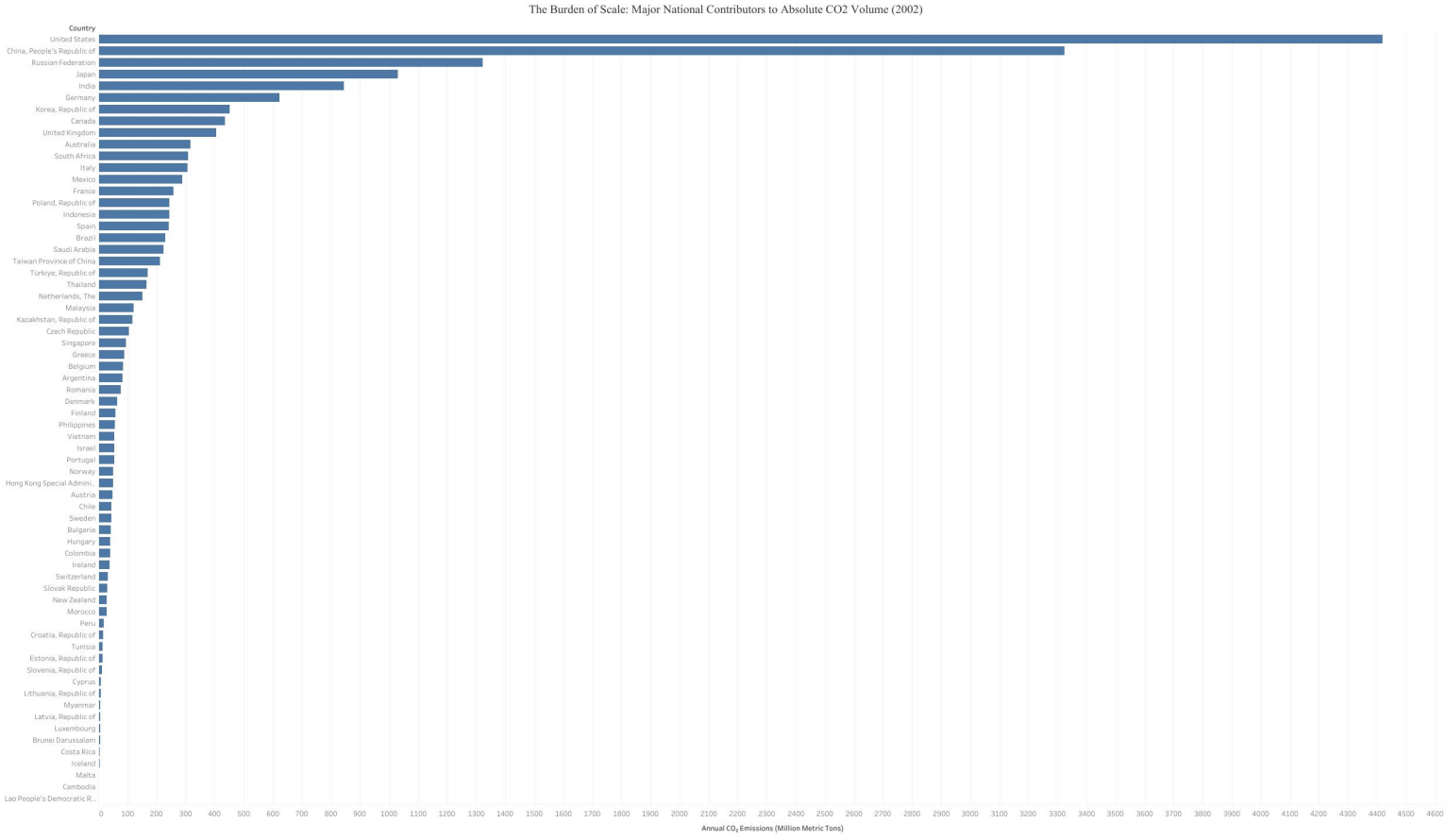

A1:Decoupling in Action: Steady Decline in Carbon Intensity per Unit of Output (1995 – 2018)




A2:The Shift to Clean Economy: Emission Intensities Across Modern Sectors(2002)




B1:Unchecked Growth: Absolute Carbon Emissions Surging to Dangerous Highs (2004-2018)




B2:The Burden of Scale: Major National Contributors to Absolute CO2 Volume (2002)

# Project 2 Checkpoint: Writeup

## 1. Propositions

**Trajectory (Decoupling vs. Crisis)**:
**Side A (Progress)**: Global economic growth is successfully decoupling from carbon emissions through long-term industrial efficiency gains.
**Side B (Crisis)**: Global climate mitigation has stalled as absolute emissions continue to surge to dangerous historic highs.
**Accountability (Legacy Sectors vs. Large Nations)**:
**Side A (Structural Shift)**: Modern high-value economies are intrinsically low-carbon; residual emissions are confined to a few legacy infrastructure sectors.
**Side B (Sovereign Burden)**: A small number of large nations dominate absolute emissions, offsetting all other countries' mitigation efforts.

## 2. Personal Stance

**Leaning**: **Side B**.
**Rationale**: Physical climate risk is governed strictly by the cumulative mass of atmospheric emissions rather than economic efficiency ratios.

## 3. Deceptive & Rhetorical Techniques Used

**Plot 1 (Side A - Carbon Intensity)**:
**Selective Normalization**: Plotted emissions per GDP unit instead of absolute emissions to show ~80% efficiency gains while concealing rising total emissions.
**Extended Baseline**: Used a 24-year timeframe (1995–2018) to create a smooth downward slope, masking short-term stagnation.
**Plot 2 (Side B - Absolute Emissions Surge)**:
**Temporal Cherry-Picking**: Isolated 2004–2018 to frame post-recession growth as a structural runaway crisis.
**Alarmist Headline Framing**: Employed emotionally charged rhetoric ("Surging to Dangerous Highs") to induce crisis urgency without contextual baselines.
**Plot 3 (Side A - Sector Intensities)**:
**Axis Compression via Outlier**: Retained extreme outlier sectors (electricity/marine transport), compressing the X-axis and flattening carbon-heavy manufacturing and mining bars to appear near-zero.
**Plot 4 (Side B - National Tonnages)**:
**Omission of Per-Capita Scaling**: Visualized raw sovereign tonnages without population adjustment, singling out a handful of large nations while obscuring per-capita differences and historical cumulative emissions.